asked him to set up an appointment for the team to meet with Ijaz Butt. It took a while to get dates and in the meantime, the tournament continued. Eventually, when Butt sat us down, all the players opened up about what their problems were with Younis.

When it was my turn to speak, I said that the issues outlined could be sorted out – there was nothing that a team couldn't resolve sitting across a table. I also recommended that Younis be called in and allowed to proactively participate in solving the problems so that we, as a team, could emerge from this situation together – not at anybody's expense.

That was the end of the meeting. Later, I approached Ijaz Butt in private and reiterated that Younis was a great captain and that he should be allowed to retain his captaincy. I emphasized that the problems the boys had should be taken to him in a transparent fashion to avoid a similar situation in the future.

The repercussions of that meeting were as expected. The atmosphere in the dressing room became quite tense and uncomfortable. Later, when Younis was eventually sacked as captain – and we were knocked out of the Champions Trophy – I was declared captain of the side, temporarily. Since I already knew everybody's mindset, I was aware of how ugly the game of team politics could get, and proceeded with caution. This was not the ideal time to wear the captain's hat. Eventually, the dissident batsman was made captain for an overseas tour. When Pakistan didn't win a single game on that tour, the same things – conspiracy and controversy – hit him too. The moral of the story is simple: if you dig a hole for others, make sure you don't fall into it yourself. Sadly, that's what happened to our rebel.

The bottom line is a stark one: the atmosphere in the dressing room in the years leading up to the 2010 spot-fixing scandal was really toxic. In my opinion, things began going downhill the day the PCB chairman at the time, Dr Nasim Ashraf, breached all traditions of seniority and experience and made Shoaib Malik the captain and Salman Butt the vice-captain. That single move tore the team apart and it took several years for Pakistan cricket to recover from it.

Here's the thing: sometimes, it's natural instinct that's the enemy. It's normal to start looking for others to blame when you lose. And, when you win, it's normal to take all the credit for yourself. That's broadly what happened to the Pakistan team in those dark days of politics and scandal. We should have taken ownership of not only our wins, but also our defeats. Sadly, we couldn't fight our natural instinct of selfishness.

By the time I was appointed captain in 2009 – first, for all T20 internationals and eventually, for ODIs – I'd learnt a few lessons the hard way, so I developed a radical approach towards my job. Delivering a standout performance on the field was not my priority – discipline was. I made it very clear to everyone that if I saw any politics in the dressing room, be it from someone who'd scored a century or from a match-winner, I would get him kicked out of the team. That was my code: discipline, minus the politics. This approach was from the Imran Khan school of thought. That was also the pact Waqar Younis, the new coach, and I had made. I'm glad that since that time, till today, we've never had a better atmosphere in the dressing room. After my innings as captain, Misbah-ul-Haq took charge of the dressing room in similar fashion and conducted proceedings wonderfully without any politics or infighting.

I hate politics. It is something we can do away with in every field and organization in Pakistan. We ooze politics and palace intrigues. The politics I saw in those difficult years in the team was the worst kind, driven by ego and self-aggrandizement. Some players had begun